

Should tech companies or governments primarily combat misinformation and disinformation?



Misinformation

is information that is incorrect or not entirely accurate information. [9]

&

Disinformation

refers to false information deliberately intended to mislead. [9]

Some Context ...

What's the importance of accurate information?



About **one in four** Americans reported sharing fabricated news. [12]



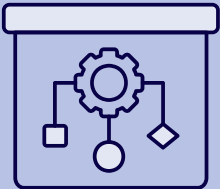
of U.S. adults say made-up news and information greatly impacts Americans' confidence in government institutions. [10]



of social media users (WhatsApp) over the age of 60 have a 38% vulnerability rate to misinformation, being impacted the most out of all ages. [8]

Current Methods ...

Algorithm Adjustments | Algorithms tend to be trained on feed curation and user engagement which unfortunately is more in favor of disinformation than not. Users can use middleware to opt in to algorithms that promote healthier, less divisive content. [1]



Increased Transparency | Organizations should be fully transparent about their sources, methods of data collection in published content, disclosing data with timeliness and in full. Transparency should also extend to the collection, sharing, storage of user information. [11]

Content Moderation | Various social media platforms have begun using content moderation algorithms such as hash-matching and machine learning to combat growth of misinformation and hateful posts. Content that displays false data is then taken down or updated. [4]



Fact Checking Partnerships | Fact-checking with third-party organizations like the International Fact-Checking Network (IFCN) which also coincides with the agreement on a Code of Principles and a network for hundreds of organization. [14]

Digital Literacy Education | Studies support that individuals with media literacy training are less susceptible to believing everything they read online. These users are more likely to analyze what they read, identify fake news, sponsored posts, and unreliable websites. [2]





Examples in Law

Section 230

47 U.S.C. § 230

"No provider or user of an interactive computer service shall be treated as the publisher or speaker of any information provided by another information content provider." [13]

This law protects protects internet service providers of any legal responsibility for information posted by users.

While it protects our First Amendment Right, it also means large tech companies aren't being held accountable. [13]

Digital Service ACT

"This Regulation fully harmonises the rules applicable to intermediary services in the internal market with the objective ... addressing ... the societal risks that the dissemination of disinformation or other content may generate." [3]

The DSA regulates online platforms such as market space, social networks, online platforms, and app stores. Preventing illegal and harmful activities online and the spread of disinformation . [3]

This law protects users and consumers in the European Union and their fundamental rights online by setting clear and proportionate rules .

Argument I..

Tech Companies should be primarily responsible ...

STRENGTHS



1) **Transparency** within companies helps users understand how their data is being used and can provide trust between users and tech companies. [6]



2) Holding tech companies accountable can foster a **safer online environment** for users and ensure they are held responsible for misusing people's personal information. [9]



3) Giving tech companies a level of responsibility can allow healthy **competition** between different companies and provide more space for smaller tech organizations to gain users. [4]

WEAKNESSES



1) Legal risk to user's speech may cause significant censorship, ultimately putting **First Amendment right** at risk. [13]



2) Potential **obstacles in the range of enforcement** of tech companies on a global scale, given the different countries and jurisdictions that exist as well as various sets of laws alongside them. [5]



3) Strict enforcement and regulations may deter certain creativities and innovations among tech companies which could **hinder potential growth**. [12]

Argument II..

Governments should be primarily responsible ...

STRENGTHS



1) Enforcing governmental responsibility can ensure the **checks and balances** of the government are intact and can protect individuals from being taken advantage of by the government. [4]



2) **User protection rights** are enforced through governmental accountability, such as lawful freedom of expressions and data usage regulations. [3]



3) Providing **tools** and **resources** for users to challenge or speak up against governmental actions that may limit user freedoms. [1]

WEAKNESSES



1) Potential **abuse of power** may occur through loopholes or by the exploitation of legislation for political gain. [7]



2) Issues may rise surrounding the jurisdictional power within differences among legal frameworks or **global disagreements** of different governments. [8]



3) Possible **limitations of resources** and knowledge in implementing government accountability measures. [7]

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